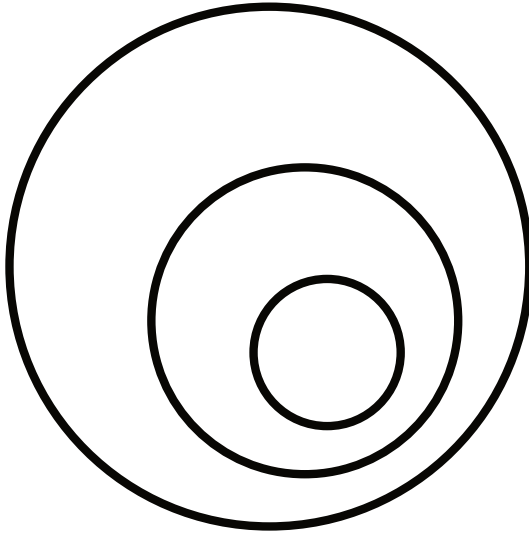


microscope **CHRONICLE**



PLAYTEST MAY 2025

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WELCOME, PLAYTESTERS!

These playtest rules are free for anyone to download and play. This is a complete revision of the first edition released as part of *Microscope Explorer*.

My best advice is to not treat it like a playtest, just play and have fun like you normally would. You can leave feedback and get the latest updates (<https://www.lamemage.com/microscope-chronicle/>), because I would love to hear how your game went.

-Ben

IF YOU'VE PLAYED MICROSCOPE BEFORE

Microscope: Chronicle is a more focused and (hopefully) accessible version of *Microscope*.

- It tightens the history to a specific thing, like a city, a sword, or a secret society, so it's easier to pick and stick to a topic.
- Each round focuses on the characters whose lives are part of that history, making the story more personal and real.

It's also a testing ground for refinements to make any game of *Microscope* better. Some changes might not be obvious at a glance, so make sure to follow the steps as written instead of relying on your memory.

WHAT YOU NEED TO PLAY

Everything in your story will be created as you play. Nothing is made in advance.

Each step starts with a summary you can read aloud to explain how to play, so you can just open up the book and follow the instructions, but it helps to have someone who has read the rules ahead of time.

You will need:

- Three to five players (alternate rules for two)
- A bunch of index cards or blank flash cards
- Pens or pencils
- At least two hours

You're going to lay cards down in a row, so instead of sitting all around the table it's useful to leave one side empty and place the cards so no one has to read upside down.

If you're playing online, you'll need a shared space where you can emulate cards on a table, or create a simple text outline.

A game can go on for as long as you want. You can play a single session, or keep coming back and exploring the same history over and over again.

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STEP 1, WHAT IS CHRONICLE?

*The exile who came to the city to start a new life,
The mason who carved blocks for its walls*

*The merchant getting rich in its marketplace,
The thief rotting in its dungeon*

*The emperor who watched it burn,
The child who plays in its ruins...*

*All these lives are part of the story of a city. You tell its story
by exploring theirs.*

In *Microscope: Chronicle* we'll create the history of a single thing, like a frontier town, a legendary sword, or an old space freighter. We'll tell the story of the Chronicle by telling the story of the people whose lives are impacted by it.

But we won't create the history in chronological order. We'll build it from the outside in, starting from the big picture and then jumping back and forth in time to explore the parts that interest us. We'll know how our story ends and then see how we got there.

We'll start off making things together, but once we're on the same page we'll switch to contributing individually, each of us building on what other players created.

Ultimately the world we create belongs to all of us, and our contributions are its most important ingredient. But be prepared for the story to turn out differently than you expect. Even though we start knowing how the history begins and ends, the story that unfolds will surprise us...

(take turns reading this introduction aloud)

STEP 2, PICK OUR CHRONICLE

Pick the thing we want explore. That's our Chronicle. It could be a city, an object, an organization, or anything in between.

Add a sentence to describe how it is different than others like it, but don't go into more detail. Details will emerge as we play. Give it a name.

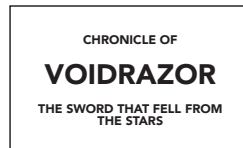
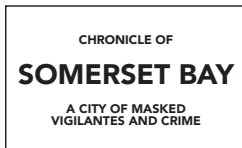
A city... plagued with crime, protected by masked vigilantes. We call it Somerset Bay.

A sword... that fell from the stars. It is called Voidrazor.

A movement... to establish equal rights for artificial people. We imagine there are many different groups over time, so we just call it the Artificial Person Movement.

The Chronicle will change over time so this description is just a snapshot. A city may be prosperous at one point, ravaged by war at another.

Don't worry if the idea seems too simple or boring. It will become interesting as you play and add detail. Write it on a card, as shown.



Need an idea for your Chronicle? You can look at this list for inspiration, or even roll and see what you get.

1 | A community, that people build together or fight over...

1 | a city, 2 | an island, 3 | a manor, 4 | a fortress,
5 | a space station, 6 | a planet

2 | An object, that passes through many hands...

1 | a sword, 2 | a crown, 3 | a ship, 4 | a pocket watch,
5 | a skull, 6 | an alien artifact

3 | Art, that inspires us or drives us away...

1 | a song, 2 | a monument, 3 | a fictional character,
4 | a TV show, 5 | a museum, 6 | a game

4 | An organization, that we believe in or imposes on us...

1 | a school, 2 | an empire, 3 | a secret society,
4 | a movement, 5 | a religion, 6 | an agency

5 | A force that changes society...

1 | an invention or breakthrough, 2 | a tradition,
3 | a law, 4 | a plague, 5 | an invasion, 6 | a revolution

6 | Something greater than us...

1 | a disaster, 2 | a curse, 3 | a mountain pass,
4 | a forest, 5 | a giant monster, 6 | a god

These descriptions are just starting points to help get you thinking. Your own Chronicle will go in whatever direction you take it.

STEP 3, BOOKENDS

As a group, decide how our story begins and ends. Make one Period at the start of our history and another at the end. Each Period is a large chunk of time, perhaps years or decades or even centuries, with even more time in between. Our whole story will take place between these two bookends.

Later on we will make more Periods to fill out what happens in between. To create our bookends:

- 1 | **Start or End:** Decide which to make first. You can create them in either order.
- 2 | **Paint the Picture:** Describe what the Chronicle is like or what happens to it during this time. Give a broad overview so you can clearly picture the idea, but don't go into detail.
- 3 | **Light or Dark:** Decide whether that Period is Light or Dark. Discuss and explain why you think it's true. Go with whatever feels right.
- 4 | Repeat and make the other bookend.

Write each Period on an index card oriented tall, as shown. Write START or END at the bottom of the card. Put the start card on the left and the end card on the right.

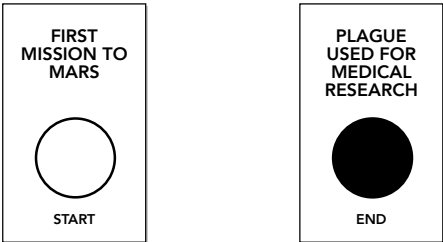
They are the earliest and latest Periods we'll explore in play, but the Chronicle might exist long before our story starts, or continue far after. This is just the part of the story that we are going to talk about.

Throughout the game, you will be asked to say whether something you are creating is Light or Dark and to explain why. You are never wrong, but your explanation is the important part. It helps us understand what other players think about what they've made. You might even find you get new insight into your own ideas as you try to explain your choice.

EXAMPLE: BOOKEND PERIODS

Our Chronicle is the Martian Plague, a disease brought back to Earth. We decide to start with a Period of the first manned mission to Mars, when they unknowingly bring back a rock with the virus. Does that means there's an outbreak? We decide that no, for now the sample is locked away and we don't even know there's a virus. We decide it's Light, because even though this lurking danger has come to Earth, it's a time of achievement and progress. We made it to Mars!

How apocalyptic do we want our ending to be? Do we want the plague to wipe out all humanity? We could, but instead we decide to have science harness it, for better or worse. Our history ends with us engineering samples of the virus and using it for medical research, to augment human evolution. We decide it's Dark, because some people are reaping these benefits and some aren't, plus we're playing God.



THE MARTIAN PLAGUE

STEP 4, PALETTE

Make a list of things we all agree belong or don't belong in our history. This palette establishes the rules for the rest of our game.

Before we create more history, we'll talk about what we want and don't want in our story. The goal is to all get on the same page about what belongs in our setting, to avoid disagreements and surprises later on.

We'll each contribute our ideas, but the palette is a discussion. We should all agree what goes on the list.

- 1 | Make columns for Yes and No on a card.
- 2 | Each player can add one thing, either to the Yes or No side. Players can go in any order.
 - Add something to the Yes side if you want it to be part of the story, and you think the other players would not expect it to be included.
 - Add something to the No side if you don't want it to be in the story, but you think the other players would expect it to belong.

Discuss each entry before writing it down. No one should be unhappy about what winds up on the Palette.

- 3 | If every player added something (either in the Yes or No column), each player gets to go again and add something else.

Keep going until someone does not have anything they want to add. When that happens, let the other players finish their contributions for this round then stop. Your Palette is done.

For the rest of the game, it is everyone's job to respect the Palette and stick to what you agreed to.

The Palette is not an exhaustive list of what will be in the story. It's a list of exceptions or surprises. If something fits the setting (like wizards in a fantasy world), you probably don't need to add it to the Yes column because the other players already expect it. Likewise, if something seems really out of place (like wizards in a science fiction setting), you probably do not need to put it in the No column unless you think other players want to include it. When in doubt, discuss.

If there is something weird you want to add to the story, now is the time to bring it up. Being surprised by what happens in the story is good, but being surprised by what belongs is not.

A player wants religion in the No column, but someone asks if that means no gods. They discuss and agree that what the player actually wants is no organized religion, no churches or priests. Gods can totally be real. They write "organized religion, churches, priests" as one entry in the No column.

<u>YES</u>	<u>NO</u>
• BINDING OATHS • FADING MAGIC • UNDEATH	• OTHER MONSTERS • WIZARDS • FANTASY RACES • CHOSEN ONES

THE DRAGON

<u>YES</u>	<u>NO</u>
• LEGACY HEROES • TEMPTATION • CRIME IS BUSINESS	• SUPERPOWERS • FLAWLESS PEOPLE • GROSS CRIMES

SOMERSET BAY

STEP 5, END DISCUSSION

So far we've been creating together, but from now on, each player contributes individually. When it's your turn, don't ask for ideas, and when it's someone else's turn don't make suggestions or coach.

But nothing we make should contradict what we've already said. If you see someone introducing a contradiction, point it out so we can fix it.

We want each player to come up with their own ideas so we can be surprised by the direction the story takes. From now on, the rules are:

- Don't coach, make suggestions, or ask for ideas. But you can always help if someone doesn't understand the rules.
- Don't contradict what we already created, including the Palette. If someone else contradicts something we established, point it out.

Coming up with names can be hard, so that is the one case where you can ask for help and collaborate.

If someone makes something unclear, you can ask for clarification, but don't sneak in your own ideas. Only ask questions that are honestly questions, not suggestions. You can also remind other players of things that we already established if they have overlooked them.

Sometimes a player will need time to form their idea and we'll have to sit and wait. That's fine. Be patient.

If you have an idea, but it's not your turn, save it! Don't talk about it, keep it secret. But always be ready to change your plans if something happens that makes your idea not work anymore. The story may not turn out as you expect, and that's part of the fun.

STEP 6, FIRST PASS

We already know how our history begins and ends, so now we'll start filling in what happens in-between.

Each player makes one Period or Event. Go in any order. A Period is a large chunk of time, like the bookends we made to start and end our history, and an Event is a specific thing that happens inside a Period.

You'll make more Periods and Events throughout the game, so see "Make Period" and "Make Event" for step-by-step instructions. You can put Events inside the bookends, just like any other Period.

STEP 7, SECOND PASS

Now we'll each go again and add more detail. Each player makes one Event or Anchor. Go in any order. Anchors are characters who are part of the story of the Chronicle, and each is connected to a particular Period.

You'll also make more Anchors as you play, so see "Make Anchor" for detailed instructions.

For the rest of the game we'll keep exploring our history and adding more detail.

CHRONICLE OF
AREA 14
EXCLUSION ZONE
REGION OF UNEXPLAINED
ANOMALIES

ANCHORS

THERESA FOSTER
MOTHER OF HIKER WHO
DISAPPEARED IN THE ZONE,
SHE/HER

ELLIS LANE
SHERIFF OF CLARK MILLS,
SMALL TOWN ON THE EDGE
OF THE ZONE, HE/HIM

PERIODS

ISOLATED
DISAPPEAR-
ANCES



LOCALS
AVOID THE
AREA



EVENTS

THERESA'S SON TELLS HER HIS
PLANS TO GO HIKING WITH
COLLEGE FRIENDS



STRANGER SNOOPS AROUND,
INVESTIGATING
DISAPPEARANCES, ARRESTED FOR
TRESPASSING



MISSING PERSON EMERGES
YEARS LATER. ELDERLY
THERESA RUSHES TO IDENTIFY
HIM, BUT IT IS NOT HER SON



EXPLORE YOUR HISTORY

For the rest of the game, we'll keep digging deeper and adding detail to our Chronicle. From now on, how you're seated determines your turn order. If you're playing online, decide on an order and write it down.

Pick one player to start, then follow these steps:

- 1 | **Our Anchor:** First player picks an existing Anchor or makes a new one. That Anchor is our focus for this round, and all history we make must relate to them and the Chronicle.

If you have an idea for an Anchor but need a new Period to put them in, you can opt to take your turn first and make a Period before you make the Anchor.

- 2 | **Take Turns:** Each player makes a **Period, Event** or **Scene** about the Anchor. Take turns, starting with the first player and going around to the left (clockwise).
- 3 | **Finish Round:** The first player takes another turn to wrap up the Anchor's story, for now.
- 4 | **Free Roam:** Person to the right of the first player (reverse direction of other steps) makes a **Period, Event, dictated Scene**, or **Anchor** anywhere in the history. It does not have to relate to an Anchor, just the Chronicle.
- 5 | **Next:** Person to the left of the first player becomes the new first player. Start again at step one.

You can keep playing and repeating this loop as long as you want. When you're ready to stop, go to "Ending the Game".

MAKE PERIOD

A Period is a major chunk of the history, years, decades, or even centuries. To make a Period, describe what your Chronicle is like during this time and how it differs from Periods around it.

Periods flow from left to right, earlier Periods on the left and later on the right. To make a Period:

- 1 | **Pick When:** The Period must be between any two adjacent Periods.
- 2 | **Describe Period:** What is this era like? How is the Chronicle different from other Periods? Give a broad overview but don't go into detail. We should be able to clearly picture what happens.
- 3 | **Light or Dark:** Don't think about future consequences, just what happened in the Period you made. Explain your choice. You're always right but we want to hear why.

Write a short summary on a card, oriented tall, and place it between the Periods you chose.

We don't specify exactly how long a Period is, but the description may give some idea. You can always add a new Period between two existing Periods, so long as you can explain how it make sense. We may think that two Periods are right next to each and then have another Period slipped in between.

EXAMPLE: MAKE PERIODS

Our Chronicle is the dragon. We know it ravages the countryside in a later Period, but a player says that in this era it slumbers in its cave, only awakening when seekers come to ask it questions. The dragon is an oracle for those brave enough to face it. But it's Dark, because even though the dragon slumbers, the land is troubled with poverty and strife. People are desperate enough to face the dragon for answers.

Our Chronicle is Pegasus Express, a courier service using biplanes to deliver the mail and keep remote rural communities connected. A player makes a Period where years of drought causes dust storms to sweep across the countryside. Crops fail, towns teeter on the edge. It sounds Dark, but the player decides it's Light. Why? Because even with all the hardship, people pull together and help each other. Pilots won't quit, despite the danger, because communities need them to stay in touch. When planes break down, engines choked with dust, mechanics work around the clock to get them flying again. They rise to the challenge.



THE DRAGON



PEGASUS EXPRESS

MAKE ANCHOR

An Anchor is a character who is part of the Chronicle's story. To make an Anchor, describe them and their connection to the Chronicle. We'll learn more about them as we play.

Anchor characters are the lens through which we see the story of the Chronicle. To make an Anchor:

- 1 | **Pick Period:** When does this person appear in the Chronicle? A Period can have more than one Anchor.
- 2 | **Describe Anchor:** What is the basic idea of this character? What is their connection to the Chronicle? Keep it short.

Estranged daughter of one of the Mars mission astronauts

Merchant who doesn't know the old blade hanging on his wall is the sword of legends

- 3 | **Name:** Give them a name and title based on that description so we can see their concept at a glance. Names are hard, so you can ask for help if you want.

Write a short summary on a card, oriented wide, and put it above the Period you chose. If there is already another Anchor on that Period, put it above that card.

The description you give is just a snapshot in time, and the person will obviously change throughout their life. A young warrior may grow old, and an idealist may grow jaded.

EXAMPLE: MAKE ANCHORS

Our Chronicle is the starship Madamas, originally a stock model-M light freighter. In the last Period it has been sent to an orbital scrapyard, so a player makes an Anchor who works there cutting up old ships. The player describes someone who has led a hard life, even in his youth. An isolated man with few prospects. One arm is a bionic replacement that is little more than scrap itself. His name is Tariq Massi.

In our Chronicle of the sword Voidrazor, there's a Period of tension between the People of the Sea and the People of the Crescents. War never erupts, but its shadow is constantly felt. A player makes an Anchor who is a ragged hermit who hides Voidrazor so no would-be conqueror can wield it. She roams to the ends of earth, seeking some place to cast the sword away and rid the world of it forever. She uses no name now, but as a girl she was called Clabhan.

TARIQ MASSI

SCRAPYARD WORKER,
CHEAP BIONIC ARM,
HARD LIFE, HE/HIM

STARSHIP MADAMAS

THE HERMIT, CLABHAN

BEARS THE SWORD IN SECRET,
WANTS TO RID THE WORLD OF
IT, SHE/HER

VOIDRAZOR

MAKE EVENT

An Event is specific thing that happens during a Period. To make an Event, say what Period it is in and describe what happens.

An Event zooms in closer and shows us what happens at a particular place and time. To make an Event:

- 1 | **Pick Period:** The Event must be inside a Period. If there are other Events in the Period, decide whether it is before or after them.
- 2 | **Describe Event:** What happens during the Event? If an Anchor is involved (or any other relevant characters) tell us what their life is like now and how old they are.
- 3 | **Light or Dark:** Don't think about future consequences, just what happened in the Event you made. Explain your choice. You're always right but we want to hear why.

Write a short summary on a card, oriented wide, and place it below the Period. Events are in chronological order going down, with higher Events earlier.

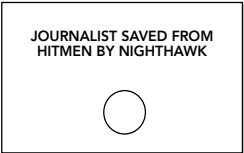
An Event must be inside a Period. If you have an idea for an Event but no Period to put it in, you can't make that Event yet. You can create Events inside the start and end bookends, just like any other Period.

If something happens in your Event and we would see the outcome, make sure to describe it. An Event should be a complete description of what happens, without going into too much detail, not a cliffhanger, unless what happens does not have a resolution.

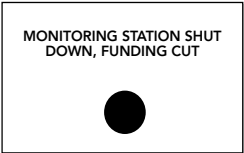
EXAMPLE: MAKE EVENTS

Our Anchor is an investigative journalist, digging into the corruption and crime rampant in Somerset Bay, so a player makes an Event where mafia hit men come to shut them up once and for all. But the other players point out that this is not a complete Event, because it doesn't describe how it turns out, so the player adds that the reporter is saved by the masked vigilante Nighthawk. It's Light, because the plot is foiled.

In another game, the Anchor is a scientist studying Area 14, so a player makes an Event where funding for their monitoring station is cut, and the last staff shuts down the facility. This is not long after the last Event we saw, so the scientist is still in their early 40s. It's Dark, because they were collecting critical data. The funding cut is political retribution and short-sightedness.



SOMERSET BAY



AREA 14 EXCLUSION ZONE

MAKE DICTATED SCENE

A Scene adds more detail to an Event and shows us what characters actually do and think at a particular moment. To make a dictated Scene, tell us where the characters are, what they do, and what they think. Show us who these people really are.

The smallest level of history is a Scene, a particular moment inside an Event that shows us what people did and thought.

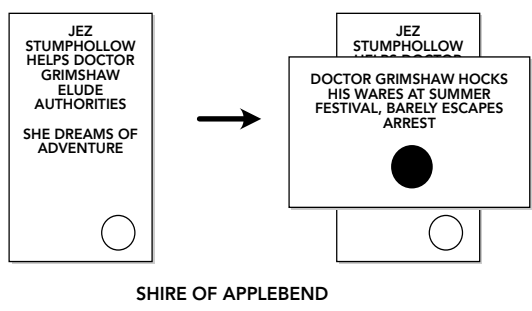
- 1 | **Pick Event:** The scene must be inside an Event. If there are other scenes in the Event, say if it comes before or after them.
- 2 | **Describe Scene:** What happens? Who is present and what do they do? What do they think or feel? Where does it take place?
- 3 | **Light or Dark:** Explain your choice. Don't think about future consequences or the broader Event, just what happened in this Scene.

Write a short summary on a card, oriented tall, and draw a smaller Light or Dark circle in the corner so it's clearly not a Period. Stack it underneath the Event card with earlier Scenes on top.

If, instead of dictating, you want to share the stage and role-play together to find out what happens, you can make a **Played Scene** instead. There are separate rules for that later on.

EXAMPLE: MAKE DICTATED SCENES

In our Chronicle of Applebend, we already have an Event where Doctor Grimshaw, mountebank and miracle worker, tries to pawn his wares at the Summer Festival and barely escapes arrest. A player decides to make a Dictated Scene to add more detail. They say that when the Wardens are hot on the Doctor's trail, they ask young Jez Stumphollow which way he went. She lies and sends them astray. Why is the Scene Light? The player says because Jez likes the charming old charlatan and is swept up by the romance of his life on the road. She dreams of a more exciting life than Applebend has to offer.



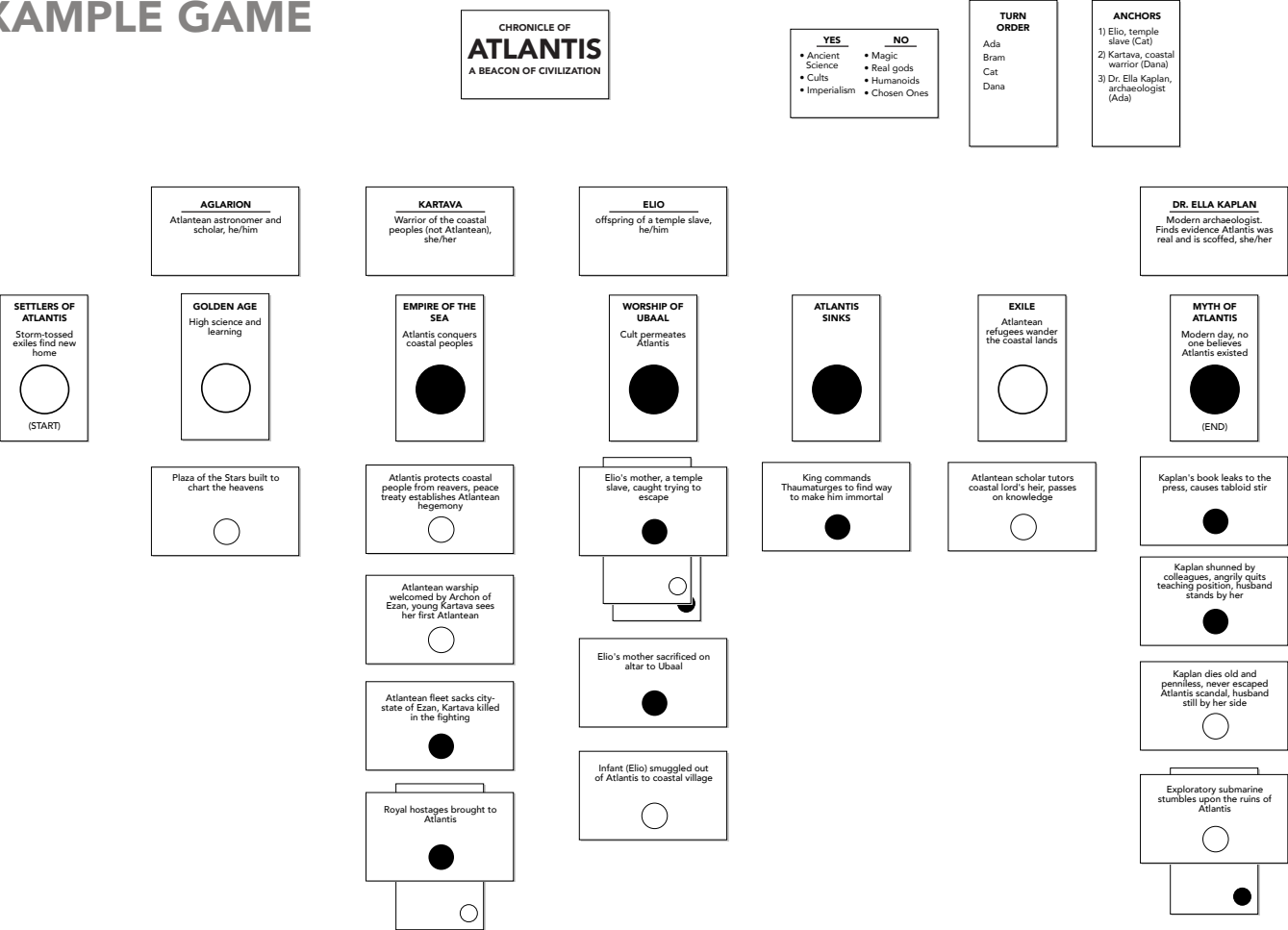
ENDING THE GAME

A game of *Microscope* has no predetermined endpoint. We know how the history ends, but you can play for as long as you want, digging deeper and deeper into the details. You might play a single session, or return to the same story later and keep playing.

When you know you need to stop soon, discuss it at the start of a round so everyone knows this will be the end. And always finish at the end of a round, after the Free Roam, since that gives the last player an opportunity to wrap up some aspect of the history.

After your game is over, and the cards are all put away, each of you may have different ideas about the world you created together, and what you would have added or wanted to change. You make something together, but each of you may take away something different.

EXAMPLE GAME





Those are all the rules you need to play. The rest are options and additions that can improve your game. Have fun playing!

PLAYING SCENES TOGETHER

Instead of just taking turns making things, you can introduce a whole new element to the game by role-playing scenes together.

When you role-play a scene you all contribute at the same time, weaving your ideas together in the moment. The player creating the scene gives up control of the outcome and lets everyone else participate. We play to see what happens.

It's a big shift from the rest of the game, and a new set of rules to learn, which is why it's optional. But playing even one scene can elevate your game dramatically. It can bring characters to life and make the whole history feel more real, in addition to letting the players stretch whole new muscles.

If you use these rules, then on your turn you can choose to make a Played Scene instead of a Period, Event, or Dictated Scene. Playing a scene takes longer than just narrating, but everyone gets to participate, so you're not hogging game time, you're sharing your turn with everyone else. You can always choose to make a Dictated Scene instead of a Played Scene if you know what you want to have happen.

MAKE PLAYED SCENE

Does the knight trust her lord? Did the captain activate the self-destruct? We can discover what happened at a particular moment by role-playing together.

Ask a question about what someone does, says, or thinks. We'll all pick characters and role-play together to find the answer. When we learn the answer, we end the scene.

Before you start role-playing, you need to prepare the scene and set the stage.

Every scene is centered around a question about some character or group of people. The question gets us all on the same page. It tells us what the scene is about. When we're playing the scene, we should be focusing on the question and looking for the answer.

To prepare the scene, follows these steps. All decisions are made by the current player, unless otherwise noted:

- 1 | **Pick Event:** The scene must be inside an Event. If there are other scenes in the Event, say if it comes before or after them.
- 2 | **Question:** Ask a yes or no question about what a person or group of people does or thinks, or something true about them.

Does the Empress tell her son his father was not a god?

Does the doctor know about the treatment's side-effects?

3 | **What, Where, When:** Tell us where this scene fits in the Event.

- **When:** Is it before or after things we already know happened in the Event?
- **Where:** Where is the scene physically taking place? We should be able to visualize where the characters are.
- **What:** What's happening right now? What we are doing here? It might not be what the scene is actually about, but it's why the characters think they are present.

4 | **Add or Ban Characters:** You can choose to specify up to two characters (or types of people) who must be in the scene and up to two who cannot be in the scene. These can be characters we already know, or people made up on the spot.

A player requires the detective's partner and an old flame, but can't also require the detective, since that would be a third character. She decides to ban the hitman who we know kills the partner later in this Event, and also bans any police.

5 | **Everyone Choses Characters:** Take turns picking who you want to play in the scene. Think about how your character will be able to influence the answer to the question.

The player making the scene chooses last. Start to their right and proceed to the right (the reverse direction of normal play).

- 6 | **Everyone Reveals Thoughts:** Tell us what your character is thinking before the scene starts. Just a short sentence or two to set the stage and maybe start some trouble. Don't answer the question.

Go in the same order that you picked characters.

The sailor is afraid his shipmates know he's a coward.

The priest is hoping the knife hidden under his smock is not noticeable.

The question could be about the Anchor or some character we've never seen before. It could be critical to the history, or something entirely personal.

How you set the scene and the question you ask can absolutely introduce new facts. If you ask a question about someone's brother, you are establishing they have a brother, even if we never heard of them before.

Think about the question carefully before you pick your character. Who you play can change how much influence you have to answer the question. If the question is about what one character does or decides, then someone playing that character will obviously have a lot of say, but other characters could still change the situation dramatically. That's why the person making the scene chooses last: they pick the question, but the other players get first choice of how to answer it.

PLAY THE SCENE

To play your scene together, tell us what your character says, thinks, and does. React to what other characters do. Move towards answering the question.

Playing a scene together is a conversation. Talk, but also listen and react to what other players do. Embrace their ideas and build on them. You can speak in-character or just summarize what your characters says.

- Focus on the question. That's what the scene is about. Even if your character can't answer the question, you can shine a spotlight on it. When you answer the question, end the scene.
- Work with what we already know and focus on the people here and now. Don't invent new facts about the world. Save that for when you are making Periods or Events.
- If you need to have a new character enter the scene, you can do so at any time, so long as it isn't someone who was banned.

Remember, we already know how the Event turns out. We may even know what happens to these characters later on, we're just adding detail in-between.

AND THEN WE FIGHT...

What happens when you describe your character doing something that someone else's character would resist, like picking their pocket or turning them into a toad?

- If what you're doing answers the question, you get to describe how it turns out, including what happens to other characters.
- Otherwise, describe what you do and what you intend the outcome to be, and the other player gets to decide the result.

Characters are temporary, and everyone dies sooner or later. Instead of trying to protect them, see how characters lives turn out.

Losing a character does not remove you from the scene. You can always introduce a new person to play.

THE ANSWER ENDS THE SCENE

When we learn the answer to the question, end the scene. It doesn't matter if the characters don't see the answer: when the players see it, even if it's something a character is thinking deep down inside, we're done.

Even if ending the scene now raises other questions or leaves action hanging, stop. If you want to see what happens next, make another scene and ask a question about that.

If anyone needs a moment for their character to react to what happened, they can describe some last thought or action, generally no more than a sentence or two, but you cannot change the answer to the question.

AFTER THE SCENE

When the Scene is over, decide as a group whether it is Light or Dark. Only judge what happened in this scene, not the broader Event or the future implications.

Discuss why you think it should be Light or Dark. This is a rare chance to talk among yourselves, so take your time. But do not talk about future implications or introduce new ideas, just what happened in the scene.

SMALLER SCENES

Sometimes it's better to have more intimate scenes with fewer characters. When you're making a scene, you can suggest keeping it small, but it's up to the other players to decide how they want to participate.

Instead of playing someone who will be in the spotlight, you can choose to stay in the background or maybe never even enters the scene. Sometimes just by declaring that a particular character exists and revealing thoughts you can put a whole new spin on the situation.

I'm the Queen's other daughter, the illegitimate one the players didn't know about until this moment. I'm not even going to show up in this scene, but I dare you not to think about me.

You can also chose to play as a Memory or Time instead of a normal character. If you want to play one of these special roles, or you plan on staying in the background, say so when you pick your character so everyone else can plan accordingly. You still have the option to introduce a new character during the scene, if you decide that's needed.

PLAY AS A MEMORY

Instead of playing a character who is present in the scene, you can play as someone from another character's past, and then inject memories of things you said and did. Describe the character and their relationship to at least one other character present in the scene.

During the scene, describe things your character said or did that the other person would have witnessed. Don't describe what other characters did—that's up to them.

I play the memory of a fellow revolutionary from the early days of the movement, talking about how much they believe what they are doing is pure and right.

The scene is a character's wedding, so I play the memory of a lover from years ago who died in the war, talking about how we'll never be apart.

PLAY AS TIME

Instead of playing a particular character, you can play as Time: a force or group of people who put pressure on the situation, because some clock is ticking...

A mob in the streets. A fire consuming the house. The rising radiation. The police about to bust in and make an arrest.

And Time doesn't have to be threatening, so long as it demands our attention.

The audience cheering for an encore. Farm animals waiting to be fed. The sunny day beckoning us to stop working and go outside.

During the scene, stay in the background, periodically injecting reminders of whatever pressure you're putting on the situation. The characters may or may deal with you, but you're creating a backdrop for the scene.

When you're playing Time, less is more. It is better to loom than intrude. Make sure they know you're there, but then sit back and give people time to play their characters. And definitely do not get in the way of answering the question.

DISCUSSION

PRINCIPLES OF MICROSCOPE

Microscope is very different from a lot of other games. If you're following all the rules but still wondering if you're playing with the right attitude, take a look at these principles. This is the philosophy the game is based on. And since this is a playtest, you can check that the rules reflect that philosophy or else I've done something wrong.

Everyone is equal. One person might explain the rules, but they have no more control over what we make than anyone else.

We each have vast power to create and destroy. But once we make something, it belongs to all of us. No one owns anything.

But that only works because we all stick to what we agreed to. We build on each other and don't contradict what's already been said.

And we want to make sure each of us does contribute. We want to hear each player's own ideas, so we don't give suggestions or try to collaborate.

But it does no good to hear someone else's ideas if you don't understand them. So every time we make something, we want to paint a clear picture that everyone can visualize.

And because the game lets us go backward and forward in time however we want, even if someone destroys something we can always go back to when it existed and explore it or expand on it more. What we've created together can never be taken away from us. The past is never closed.

Does that all sound right? If so, you're probably playing proper *Microscope*, and I made the game I intended.

THE PLAYERS ARE MORE IMPORTANT THAN THE GAME

There's one more principle, which is the most important part of any system you might play, which is that the players are always more important than the game.

The rules of *Microscope* say you can't give suggestions or veto someone else's idea, and you should absolutely follow those rules right up until the point where something in our story makes a player uncomfortable. When that happens, forget the rules and take that material out.

The key word is "uncomfortable". You might not like someone else's idea, or have an idea you prefer more, but that's part of the game: you don't always get what you want, because other people's preferences matter just as much as yours. But when we cross the line from "I don't like that" to "I don't want to be here", we need to change course or stop the game.

The Palette is there to help get us on the same page about the kind of thing we want in our game, but it is impossible to foresee or predict everything that might come up. It could be something obvious, like dark topics, but it could be something no one else could see coming, like the name of a real person a player would rather not think about.

I always say, if something makes you uncomfortable, say so. But it can be very hard to admit that you are uncomfortable. It can feel like a failure, but it's not. You are making the game better for everyone by being honest and helping us avoid treacherous ground.

Everyone at the table can help avoid problems by paying attention to the other players. If you suspect someone else is uncomfortable, ask the table if this material is okay. Don't ask anyone to explain why something makes them uncomfortable, just identify the problem and change it. Even if it takes some editing and negotiating, make the fix. We're

smart people, we can adjust and make things work. Then go right back to the normal rules.

There is no silver bullet. No matter how much you try to get on the same page, you can still be surprised. Does this happen often? No, but when it does, it can ruin your whole game. Just pay attention to each other, respect each other, and be willing to change course. If you care more about the players at the table—including yourself—than the game you're playing, everything else follows.

TWO-PLAYER GAMES

You can play *Microscope: Chronicle* with only two players using these simple rule changes:

- In the First and Second Pass, both players go twice, alternating turns
- Each round, each player goes again and takes a second turn, with the current player taking an extra turn at the end as usual (A-B-A-B-A)

But keep in mind that a two-player game will always have a very different dynamic than even a three person game. You have fewer brains to draw from and fewer opportunities to be surprised by someone else's ideas. And you are also more likely to build directly on your own creations.

You are also the only person who can react to what the other player is making. If you aren't immediately interested in their idea, there is no one else to take it and run with it. That can be a lot of pressure for both players. Even if the steps look a lot like a normal game, the vibe can be very different.

Two-player sessions can definitely can work, but you should keep these issues in mind, adjust your expectations, and cut each other slack.

PUTTING CARDS AWAY

If you want to save your history so you can play again or look at it later, put the cards away in order so you can deal them back out again.

Start in the upper left with your first Period and then work your way down, putting each card you pick up on the bottom of the stack. Then move to the next Period and do the same. You'll wind up with a single stack in chronological order with the very earliest part of the history on the top. Put the card with the name of your Chronicle on the very top to label the stack. When you want to play again, deal out the cards from the top and use the changes in orientation to indicate when you come to the next Period, etc.

TALK BEFORE YOU WRITE & LIGHT OR DARK

You're going to write a lot of notes on index cards, but here's the secret: what you write down doesn't really matter. What matters is what each of the players at the table hears and remembers. The cards are just placeholders, notes to remind us of what was said. They cannot possibly ever include every idea or nuance that was introduced.

So when it's your turn, start by not writing anything. Just talk and explain what you're making. Often you'll find that as you try to express what's in your head, your idea will shift or become more clear. You'll stumble over bits and then suddenly it will click, and you'll say "okay, wait, now I've got it!"

That's normal and good. We want you to think through your ideas and tell us what you're really thinking. If you start writing first, you have to constantly go back and scratch out your early drafts. But when you talk and explain you can figure out the real shape, and then write a nice simple summary.

After all, the card is not your audience. The other players listening are. You're explaining the idea to them.

This is also one of the reasons the game asks you to pick Light or Dark, because we want you to think about what you made, to give us insights into what you care about and what you think it all means. Because even when you feel like your idea is fully formed, when you start explaining why its Light or Dark and suddenly you have even more ideas about what it means and how it all fits together.

All these steps are designed to help you form your ideas and communicate them to the other players. We're making up whole worlds: it's a lot to absorb. The potential to misunderstand each other—or even to misrepresent our own ideas—is huge. And the game is all about understanding each other.

MAY 2025 UPDATE

This page is the only change from the last playtest release. If you've already read the previous rules, this is all you have to look at to get caught up.

There are no rules changes, just two clarifications:

- The Anchor is not limited to the Period they are placed on. They can appear in other Periods.
- The history you make has to "relate" to the Anchor, but that person does not have to be present or even alive.

Our Anchor is Elspa, a humble inn-keeper in a remote community of scholars. A player makes an Event in a Period centuries after the Anchor is dead and the community has been destroyed, where history incorrectly remembers her as a war-hero and a school is named in her honor, Elspa Academy. The Anchor is long gone, but the Event clearly relates to her.

Often a character only appears in one Period, but a character could appear in Events or Scenes in more than one Period, if that makes sense for how the Periods were described and how much time passed. But I recommend doing this sparingly, since it ties your Periods together very closely together chronologically and gives you less room to explore.